an actual war, I would not have hesitated to sack the CO on the spot. Since the aim of such exercises is to train and to learn from mistakes, I did not harm his career. Instead, I gave them another 12 hours in which to prepare and occupy a well-sited and dug-up battalion-defended area capable of withstanding an armoured assault accompanied with heavy shelling. The next morning, their defences would be inspected by my brigadier general staff, who would then report to me.

Similarly, I went to observe the tank and infantry manoeuvres, and gave orders to increase the tempo of the exercise even higher. In such major exercises, it had become the accepted norm that once the main offensive force had captured and secured the areas up to the first phase line, and the air drop of the para battalion with the 'heavy drop' had been accomplished successfully, the exercise was terminated. So at first, my decision to continue the manoeuvres caused some consternation in the fighting formations as well as the logistics units. But soon thereafter, it felt great to see the adversaries going for each other, and trying to win their battles. We had put in place an effective umpire organization. It was tasked to announce the result of each engagement as fast as possible, if not almost instantaneously. These decisions were not based on gut feelings of the control organization, but on the basis of scientific value-based software evolved by us, keeping in mind both the tangible and intangible factors.

This important training event came to a successful conclusion once we had achieved the aim set out by us. The final act was the summing up, in which we highlighted the lessons learnt and our strengths and weaknesses. It was an important occasion for me to share my views with my leaders – the battalion and regimental commanders, the brigade and divisional commanders and the staff officers. I literally flew into the site of the summing up, and landed right in front of a huge dome made of camouflage nets under which my gallant team of warriors had been assembled. There were about 400 officers, including quite a few women officers, who had participated in the exercise. In my address, I reminded them of our